

14 October 2024 | ADVANCED DESIGN

Set Design Definition

- Creation of physical spaces that support the film's story.
- Goes beyond walls and furniture to create atmosphere.
- Communicates tone, mood, and context of a scene.

Early Cinema (1890s-1930s)

Set design inspired by theater, with painted backdrops and props.

Example:

A Trip to the Moon (1902), using hand-painted sets for fantasy landscapes.

Golden Age of Hollywood (1930s-1950s)

Large-scale, elaborate sets for visual spectacle.

Example:

Gone with the Wind, Singin' in the Rain - grandeur and romantic detail.

Modernist and Realist Influences (1960s-1980s)

Desire for realism in set design, reflecting real-world environments.

Example:

Taxi Driver - gritty urban settings that feel like characters themselves.

Contemporary Trends (1990s-Present)

Mixed reality with CGI and practical sets.

Example:

Avatar (fantastical CGI worlds) and Parasite (realistic sets symbolizing class struggle).

Design Process of Film Sets

Step 1: Script Analysis

- Analyze the script to understand mood, themes, and characters.

Example: For a horror film, sets might be darker, confined, and unsettling.

Step 2: Concept Development

- Brainstorm ideas, create mood boards, collect reference images, and sketch initial ideas.
- Focus on the overall aesthetic and how to communicate the film's tone.

Step 3: Set Planning and Design

- Create technical drawings, models, and digital renderings.
- Use 3D modeling software like Rhino to visualize the set's scale and layout.

Step 4: Set Construction and Dressing

- Build the set according to plans, then dress it with furniture, props, and textures to create a lived-in feel.

Step 5: Collaboration with Other Departments Work with the director, cinematographer, and lighting designers to ensure the set aligns with the film's visual needs.

- Lighting can significantly affect the set's atmosphere.

Step 6: On-Set Adjustments

- Make adjustments during shooting for camera angles

Examples

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Fantasy Example: The Lord of the Rings

- Sets like Rivendell and Hobbiton blend natural landscapes with fantasy architecture.
- Set designers had to make Middle Earth feel authentic by merging real-world elements with detailed fantasy environment.

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Realism Example: Parasite

- The house is designed to reflect the film's themes, contrasting the sleek upper-class home with the cramped basement apartment.
- This visual metaphor enhances the narrative's depth.

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Experimental Example: Inception

- Set design plays with architectural principles to create dream-like spaces.
- Designers used physical models and digital effects for sets that defy reality, such as the folding city and the rotating hallway fight scene.